

Session programme

Marking and intercepting to stop goals



Contents

Week one: dynamic defending	3
Week two: dynamic defending revisited	5
Week three: be on guard to intercept	7
Week four: be on guard to intercept revisited	9
Week five: space invaders	11
Week six: front to back, defend to attack	13

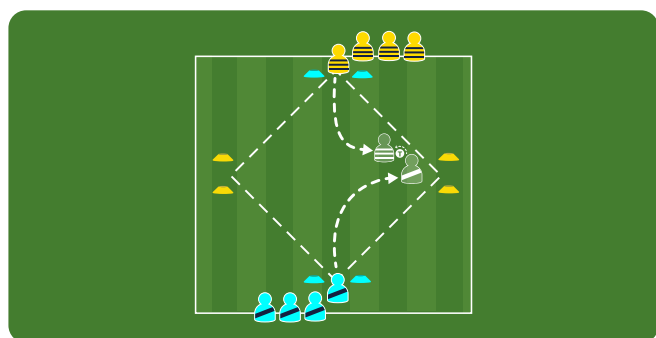
Week one: dynamic defending

This session will help players:

- to become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- who try to use scanning, movement and positioning skills when marking an individual
- to understand the role of covering and communication when defending in pairs.

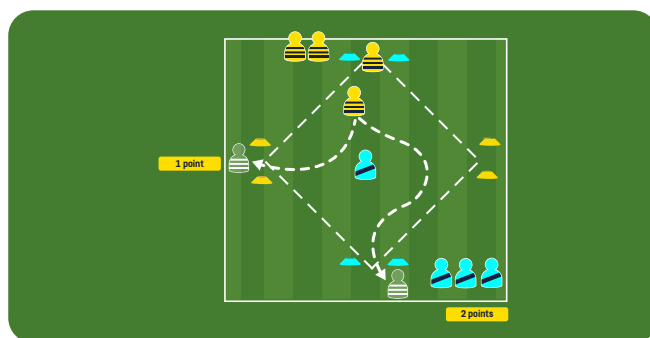
Coaching points

- Adapt movement to track runs and the movement of the opponent.
- Scan effectively to make good decisions about marking an opponent or space.
- Use a side-on body position when marking tight and covering spaces.
- Use quick movement to get into a covering position.
- Mirror first defender's body position to enable effective scanning.
- Give early and clear communication to the first defender.



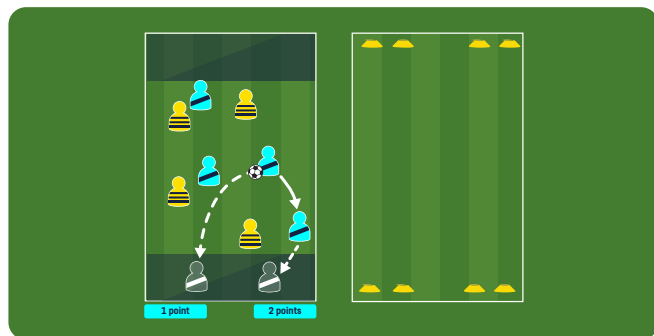
Arrival activity

- Set up a 10x10-yard diamond-shape. Put two cones down at each point to create four gates.
- Have up to four attackers behind a gate and four defenders behind the gate opposite.
- An attacker shouts "go" and runs to get through another gate. At the same time, a defender tries to tag them.



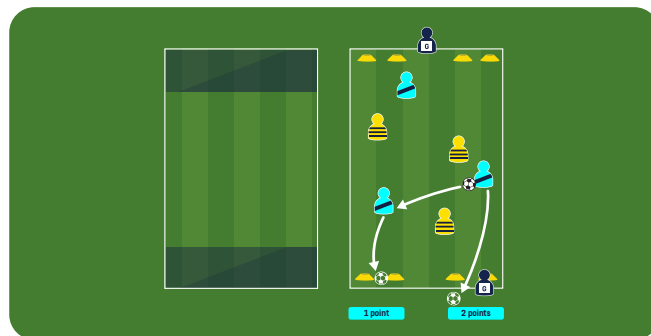
Arrival activity – continued

- Players get a point for getting through a side gate and two points for getting through the defenders' gate.
- After all three attackers have had a go, the teams swap roles.



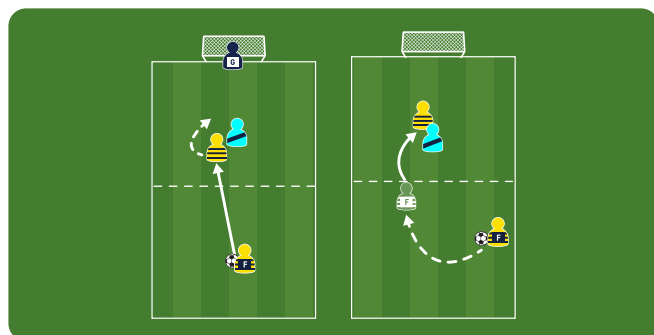
Practice one

- Create parallel 20x15-yard pitches for 3v3 or 4v4 games.
- Have end zones on the first pitch.
- Here, teams score a point for dribbling the ball into an end zone.
- They get two points if they pass the ball into the zone for a teammate to control. The receiver can only be in there for five seconds.



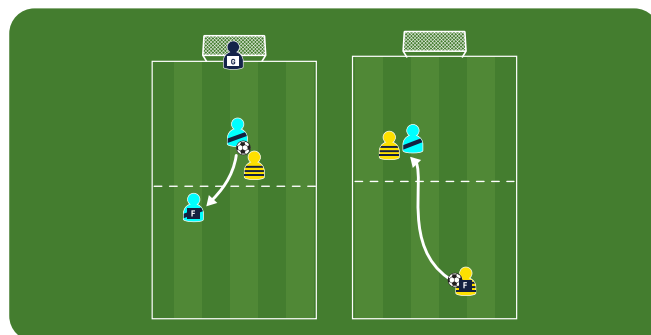
Practice one – continued

- On the other pitch, have two gates at each end with a goalkeeper behind them.
- Teams get a point for passing the ball through a gate.
- They get two points if they pass through a gate for the keeper to receive.
- Passes need to be below shoulder height.



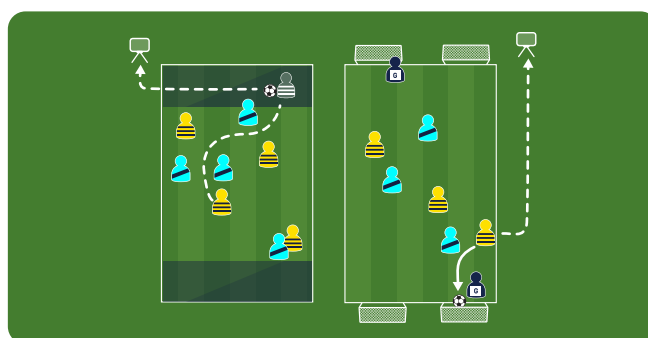
Practice two

- Set up multiple 20x15-yard pitches with a goal at one end. Have an attacker, defender and a feeder. Add a goalkeeper if using groups of four.
- The feeder passes to the attacker and they try to score. The defender needs to mark the attacker and force them away from goal.



Practice two – continued

- The attacker can use the feeder player as a passing option if needed.
- After three goes, all players rotate positions and the practice restarts.



Practice three

- Return to the parallel games. But this time, replace the gates with goals on the second pitch.
- Add the rule for both pitches: when a goal is scored, the scorer runs off the pitch to record the goal on a whiteboard or using cones as counters. This provides an overload for a short time.

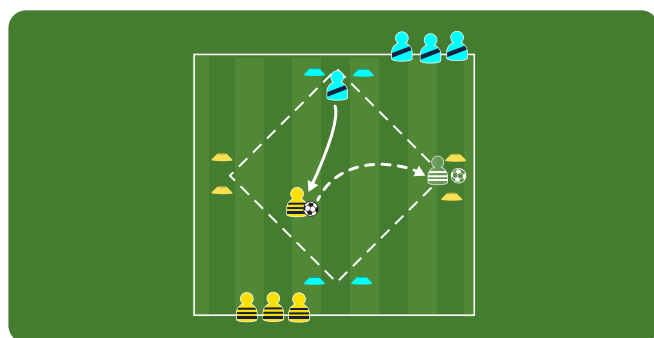
Week two: dynamic defending revisited

This session will help players:

- to become positive and enthusiastic defenders
- who try to use scanning, movement and positioning skills when marking an individual
- to understand the role of covering and communication when defending in pairs.

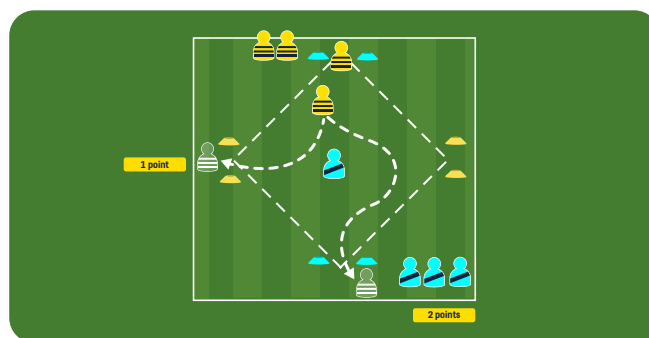
Coaching points

- Adapt movement to track runs and the movement of the opponent.
- Scan effectively to make good decisions about marking an opponent or space.
- Use a side-on body position when marking tight and covering spaces.
- Use quick movement to get into a covering position.
- Mirror first defender's body position to enable effective scanning.
- Give early and clear communication to the first defender.



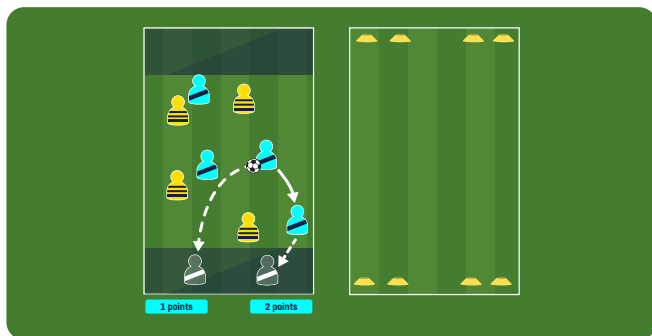
Arrival activity

- Set up a 10x10-yard diamond-shape. Put two cones down at each point to create four gates.
- Have up to four attackers behind a gate and four defenders behind the gate opposite.
- This time, a defender starts the game by passing to the attacker. The attacker then tries to dribble through a gate.



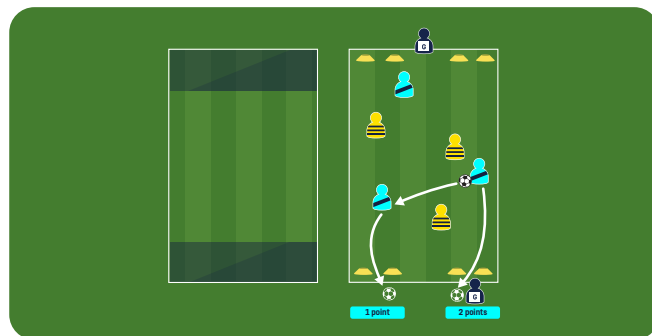
Arrival activity – continued

- Attackers get a point for getting through a side gate and two points for getting through the defenders' gate.
- Defenders need to stop them from reaching any gate.
- After all three attackers have had a go, the teams swap roles.
- This can be progressed to a 2v1 or 2v2 activity.



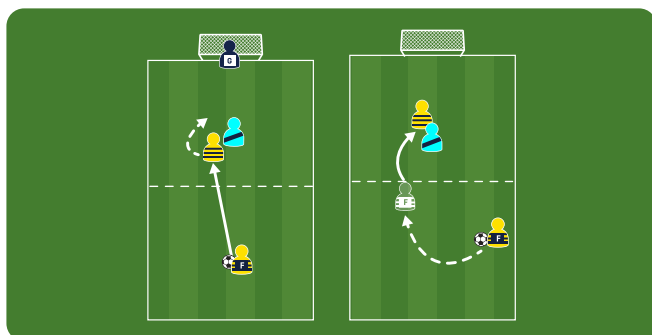
Practice one

- Create parallel 20x15-yard pitches for 3v3 or 4v4 games.
- Have end zones on the first pitch.
- Here, teams score a point for dribbling the ball into an end zone.
- They get two points if they pass the ball into the zone for a teammate to control. The receiver can only be in there for five seconds.



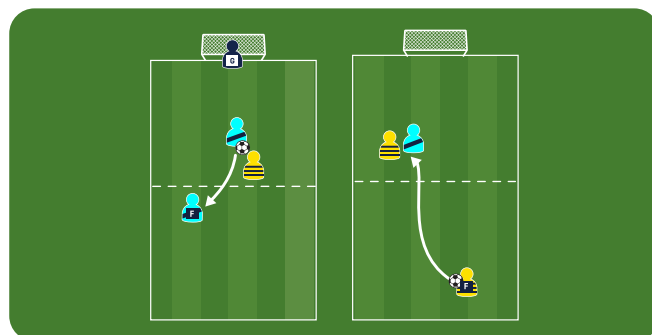
Practice one – continued

- On the other pitch, play a four-goal game. Put two mini-goals at each end with a goalkeeper.
- Teams get a point for each goal they score.
- If mini-goals aren't available, use cones to create gates for the keepers to protect.



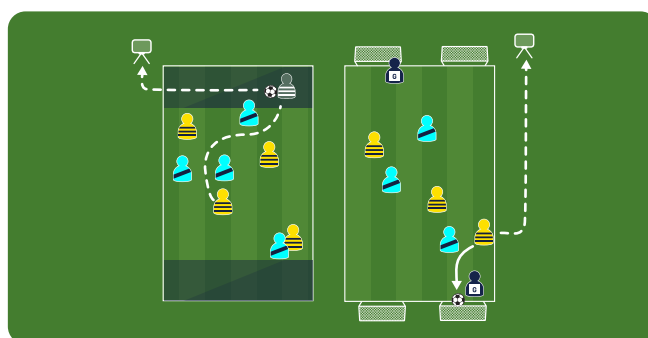
Practice two

- Set up multiple 20x15-yard pitches with a goal at one end. Have an attacker, defender and a feeder. Add a goalkeeper if using groups of four.
- The feeder passes to the attacker and they try to score. The defender needs to mark the attacker and force them away from goal.



Practice two – continued

- The attacker can use the feeder player as a passing option if needed.
- After three goes, all players rotate positions and the practice restarts.



Practice three

- Return to the parallel games. But this time, replace the gates with goals on the second pitch.
- Add the rule for both pitches: when a goal is scored, the scorer runs off the pitch to record the goal on a whiteboard or using cones as counters. This provides an overload for a short time.

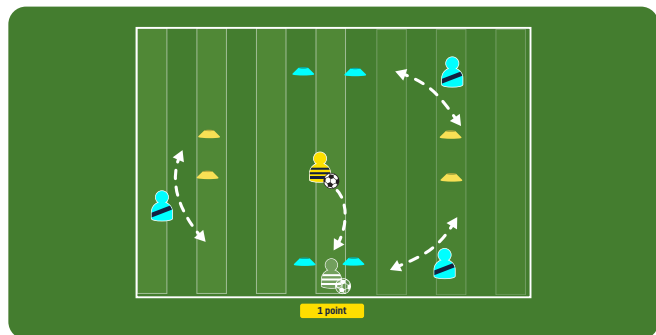
Week three: be on guard to intercept

This session will help players:

- show intelligence when making decisions as defenders
- add timing and deception skills when marking as an individual
- understand the core skill of intercepting when defending in pairs and units.

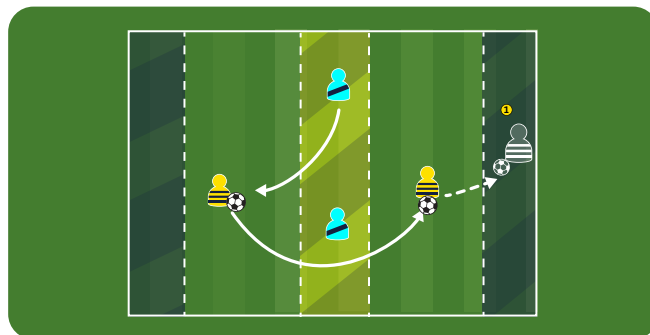
Coaching points

- Consolidate coaching points from the first two weeks.
- When intercepting, judge whether it's possible by trying to see path of the ball and nearby attackers.
- Decide to use 'best' surface for making first contact on the ball.
- Execute an interception with a positive first touch.



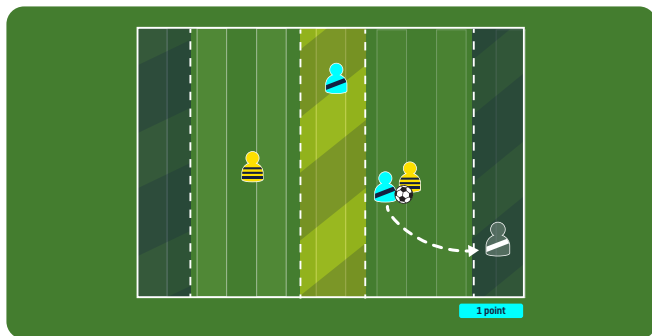
Arrival activity

- For "on guard", set up four gates in a 10x10-yard area.
- Have an attacker with a ball in the middle and three defenders around the outside.
- The attacker escapes through a gate for a point.
- Defenders scan and move to block gates.
- Change roles after 30 seconds or when the attacker gets three points.



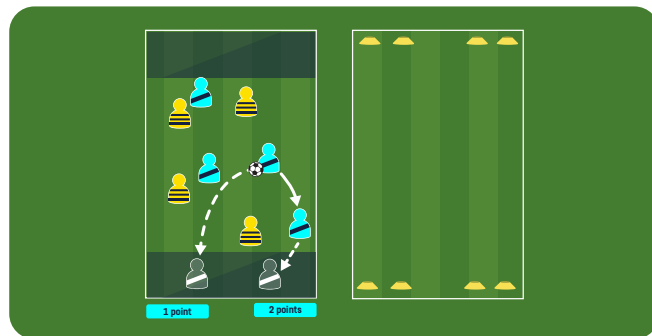
Practice one

- Create a 20x10-yard area with end zones and a middle zone.
- Have two 'interceptors' in the middle zone with a 'passer' in each area between the zones.
- An interceptor passes to a passer to start the game.
- The passer needs to pass to their teammate, who then dribbles into the end zone for a point.



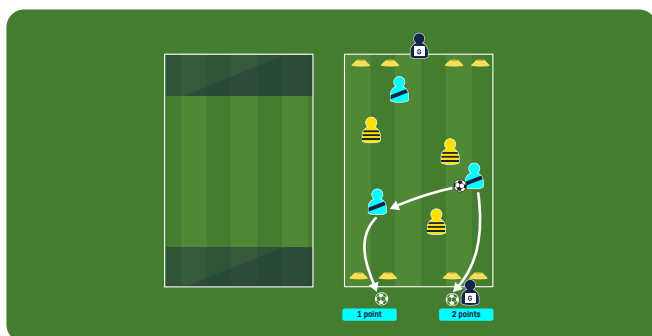
Practice one – continued

- The interceptors try to block the pass.
- One of them can also come out of the middle zone to press.
- If they win the ball, they can break out to try to dribble to an end zone to score a point.
- Play for up to five rounds then the teams change roles.



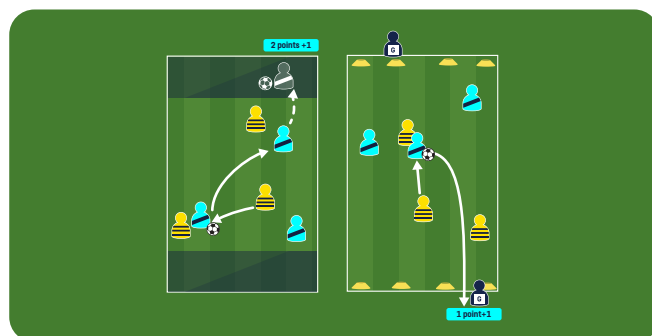
Practice two

- Create parallel 20x15-yard pitches for 3v3 or 4v4 games.
- Have end zones on the first pitch.
- Here, teams score a point for dribbling the ball into an end zone.
- They get two points if they pass the ball into the zone for a teammate to control.
- The receiver can only be in there for five seconds.



Practice two – continued

- On the other pitch, play a four-goal game.
- Put two mini-goals at each end with a goalkeeper.
- Teams get a point for each goal they score.
- If mini-goals aren't available, use cones to create gates for the keepers to protect.



Practice two – continued

- To incentivise intercepting, and differentiate the practice from previous weeks, amend the scoring system.
- Now, if the team out of possession intercept the ball and score during that phase of play, they gain a bonus point.

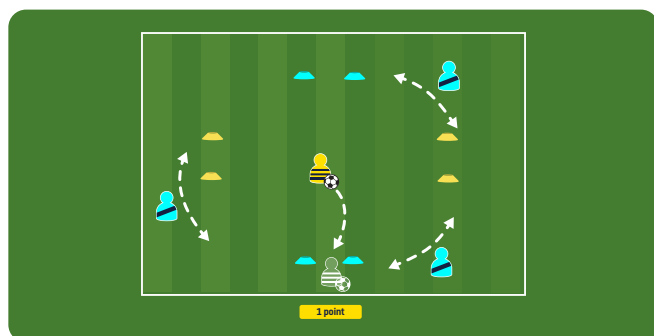
Week four: be on guard to intercept revisited

This session will help players:

- show intelligence when making decisions as defenders
- add timing and deception skills when marking as an individual
- understand the core skill of intercepting when defending in pairs and units.

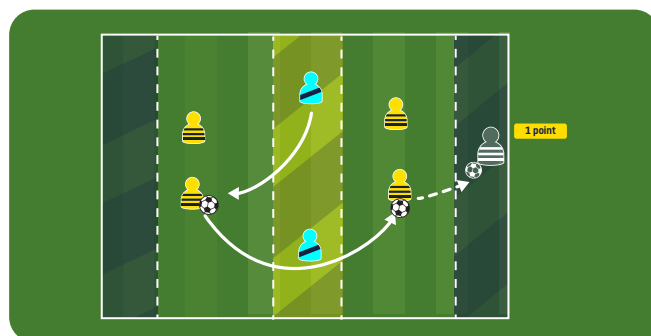
Coaching points

- Consolidate coaching points from the first two weeks.
- When intercepting, judge whether it's possible by trying to see path of the ball and nearby attackers.
- Decide to use 'best' surface for making first contact on the ball.
- Execute an interception with a positive first touch.



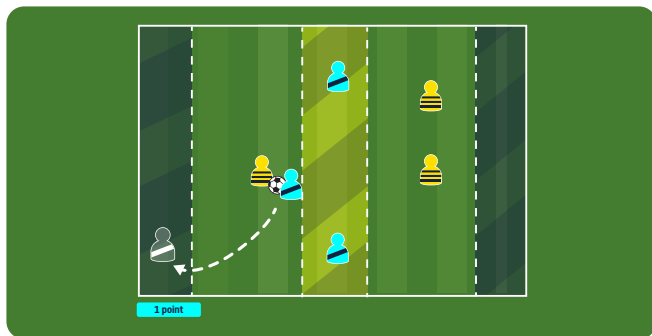
Arrival activity

- For "on guard", set up four gates in a 10x10-yard area.
- Have an attacker with a ball in the middle and three defenders around the outside.
- The attacker escapes through a gate for a point.
- Defenders scan and move to block gates.
- Change roles after 30 seconds or when the attacker gets three points.



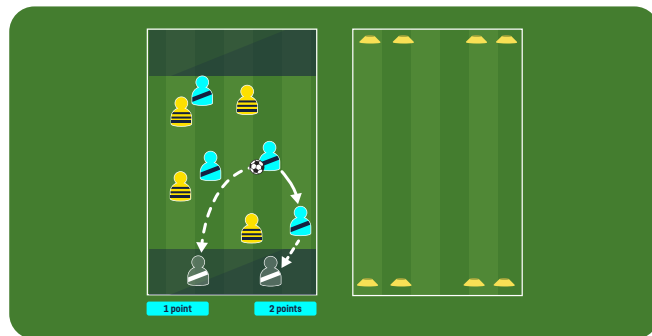
Practice one

- Create a 20x10-yard area with end zones and a middle zone.
- Have two interceptors in the middle zone with two passers in each half. Or make it a 3v3 game.
- Passers need to pass to a teammate in the other half, who then dribbles into the end zone for a point.
- Interceptors try to block the pass.



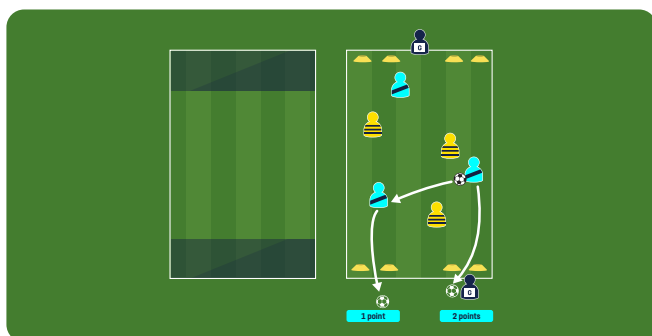
Practice one – continued

- One interceptor can come out of the middle zone to press.
- If you have three interceptors, have two in the middle zone with the other pressing. If they win the ball, they can break out to try to dribble to an end zone to score a point.
- Play for up to five rounds then the teams change roles.



Practice two

- Create parallel 20x15-yard pitches for 3v3 or 4v4 games.
- Have end zones on the first pitch.
- Here, teams score a point for dribbling the ball into an end zone.
- They get two points if they pass the ball into the zone for a teammate to control.
- The receiver can only be in there for five seconds.



Practice two – continued

- On the other pitch, play a four-goal game.
- Put two mini-goals at each end with a goalkeeper.
- Teams get a point for each goal they score.
- If mini-goals aren't available, use cones to create gates for the keepers to protect.



Practice two – continued

- To incentivise intercepting, and differentiate the practice from previous weeks, amend the scoring system.
- Now, if the team out of possession intercept the ball and score during that phase of play, they gain a bonus point.

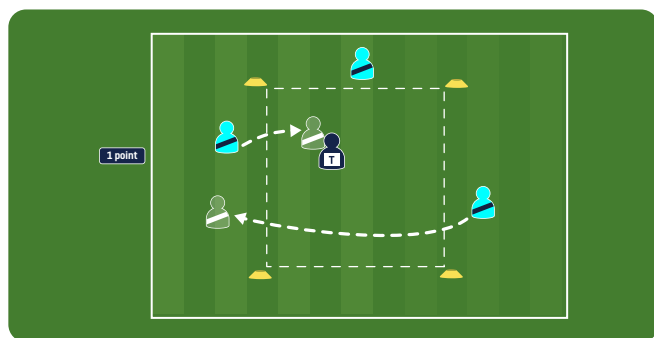
Week five: space invaders

This session will help players:

- demonstrate positive, enthusiastic, and intelligent defending
- refine their skills and decision-making around marking and intercepting when defending as individuals, in pairs, and units
- follow up winning the ball with positive actions.

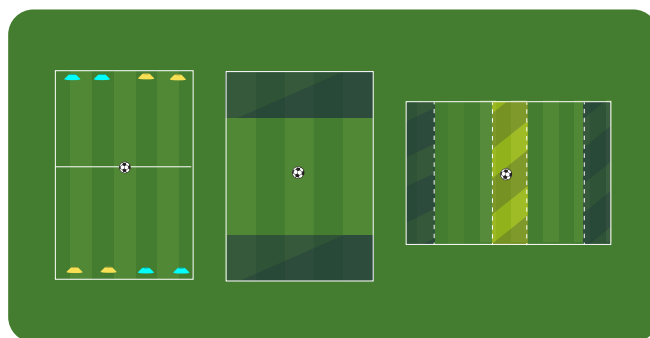
Coaching points

- Consolidate the coaching points of the previous four weeks.
- Use previous learning to aid decision-making to skilfully mark, cover and intercept.



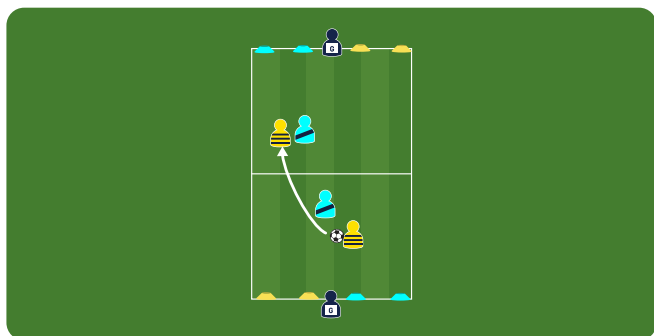
Arrival activity

- Set up a 10x10-yard area using four cones.
- Have a tagger inside the square with three other players on the outside.
- Those players aim to get across to the opposite side of the area without being tagged.
- The tagger gets a point per shoulder tag they make.
- After three tags, the tagger swaps roles.



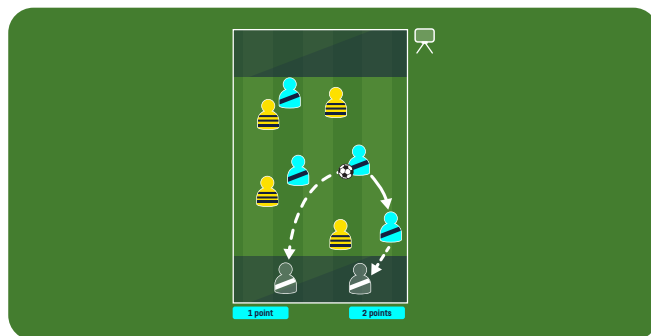
Carousel practices

- Set up three 20x15-yard pitches to play games from previous weeks.
- Players will rotate around the carousel of activities every 12-15 minutes.



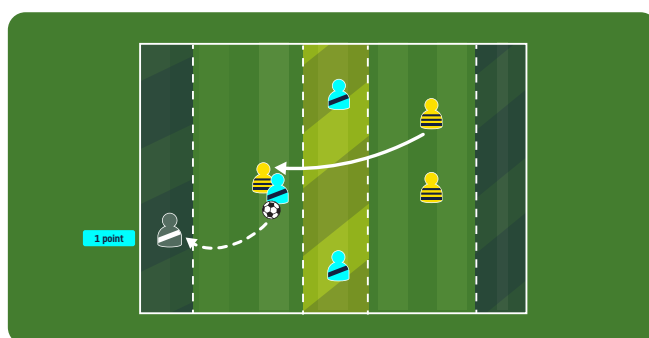
Carousel – practice one

- On pitch one it's the four-goal game.
- Create a halfway line and lock players in to create a 1v1 in each half with a keeper guarding two mini-goals.
- Players combine with their teammate and try to score.
- When out of possession, the focus is on marking and intercepting to get the ball back to attack.



Carousel – practice two

- Have end zones on pitch two.
- Here, teams score a point for dribbling the ball into an end zone.
- They get two points if they pass the ball into the zone for a teammate to control.
- The receiver can only be in there for five seconds.
- The scorer must then run to record the goal on a whiteboard.



Carousel – practice three

- Have end zones and a middle zone on pitch three.
- Two passers are locked in one half with one in the other.
- Have two interceptors in the middle zone with a third allowed out to press.
- Passers combine to get into an end zone to score.
- Interceptors need to win the ball back then break out to score.

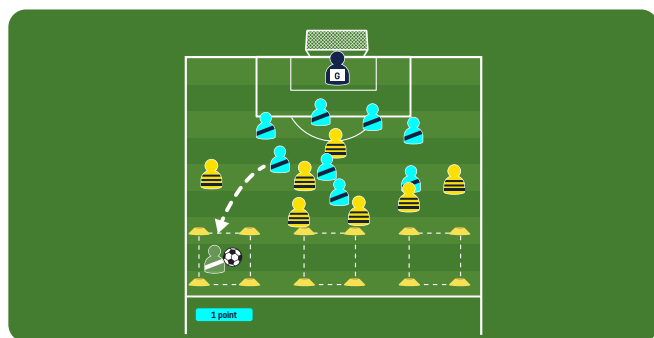
Week six: front to back, defend to attack

This session will help players:

- demonstrate positive, enthusiastic, and intelligent defending
- refine their skills and decision-making around marking and intercepting when defending as individuals, in pairs, and units
- follow up winning the ball with positive actions.

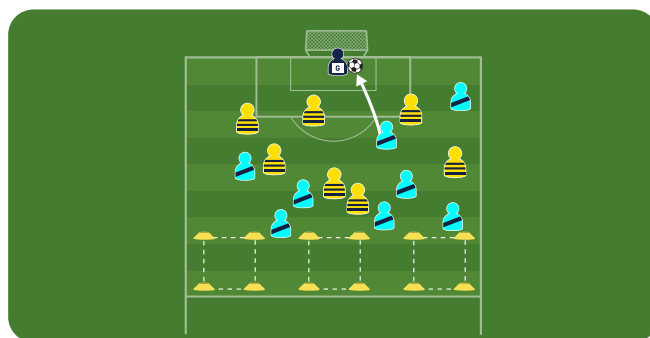
Coaching points

- Consolidate the coaching points of the previous four weeks.
- Use previous learning to aid decision-making to skilfully mark, cover and intercept.



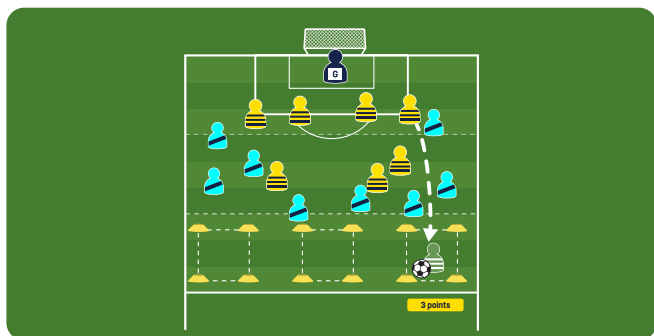
The game

- On half a pitch, have a goal and a keeper at one end.
- Put three squares at the other end.
- The defending team has eight outfielders and a keeper and face seven attackers.
- Defenders score a point for controlling the ball in any square.
- The attackers score three points for scoring in the main goal.



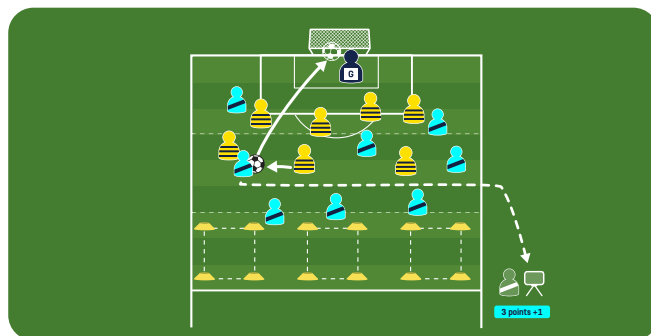
The game – continued

- Play offside for the team attacking the main goal but don't use it for the side attacking the squares.
- After seven minutes, rotate the teams.
- This then becomes an 8v8 for a round with a keeper always being on the side defending the main goal.



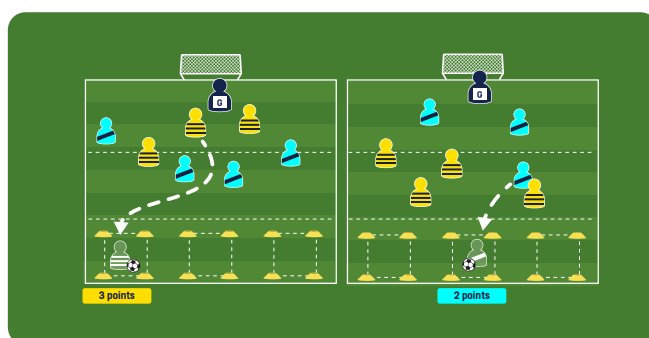
The game – progression one

- Progress the game after two rounds.
- Now, defenders get three points for winning the ball in their third and scoring. Two for doing that from the middle. And one for doing that from the final third.
- The attackers get a bonus point if they intercept then score in the main goal.



The game – progression two

- After another two rounds, progress the game further by asking the scorer to run off the pitch to record their goal on a whiteboard. This makes the scoring team a player down for a short time.



The game – small-sided version

- This activity can also be played as two smaller games – particularly if you're working with U12s or U13s.
- In this scenario, combine the scores from both pitches into one scoreline.
- Also manage the rotation of players across both pitches if needed.